Light

By Jeni Mahoney

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Most people only think about cults when they capture the front page, usually when people die or when someone close to us has been affected.*

ACTRESS 2: *Maybe you can remember the 39 members of Heaven's Gate. Or further back with the Jim Jones tragedy when over 900 people who followed their leader and committed suicide.*

ACTRESS 1: *We often believe it happens to others and it can't happen to me or my family and friends. This has proven to not be so.*

ACTRESS 2: *The type of people who join cults are typicallyno different than the vast majority of society. Some have been experiencing a time of stressful transition or a temporary crisis.*

ACTRESS 1: *Such is the case in Jeni Mahoney's short play Light*

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[At rise: Two women sit facing each other: One is "giving light" to the other. Helena (giving light) is intensely involved; eyes closed and hands poised, palms out. Abby (getting light) stares strangely at Helena not sure what to make of it. They sit this way for about fifteen seconds. A stack of booklets sits near Helena's feet.]

ABBY: Is it working?

HELENA: Shhhhh ... *[Ten more seconds of silent light-giving.]*

ABBY: I don't feel anything ...

HELENA: Shhhhhhl

ABBY: Helena - [Helena *drops her hand in disgust.]*

HELENA: Geez! Of course you can't feel it. You're thinking about it too much. You're blocking the light with your negative, doubting attitude.

ABBY: I was just checking in.

HELENA: You don't need to check in.

ABBY: I mean, I was sitting there for a good five ... six minutes and I was just

wondering if everything was okay. I mean, maybe you could feel if it wasn't going right.

HELENA: I can only give the light. I can't tell if you're receiving it.

ABBY: Oh. [Abby *considers this.]* How do I know if I'm getting the light?

HELENA: You have to be ready for the light to penetrate you. Otherwise it just bounces right off you-

ABBY: Uh-huh.

HELENA: In fact, I probably shouldn't even be giving you light. It can be dangerous if you're not ready for it. That's what happens when someone spontaneously combusts.

ABBY: *[Amused.]* Spontaneously combusts?

HELENA: It happens more than you think.

ABBY: Spontaneous combustion?

HELENA: Sure. They try to explain everything like it's something else like it's all so easy. Like it's science. There are forces-in the government and politics and stuff-that want to take away all the mysteries of the world. Like in Sunday school they tell you to "dwell on the mystery," but at the same time they try to explain it all with logic and rationalizations. They present evidence as if evidence creates truth. But evidence-empirical evidence-is a trap. Like Dac says: a demon in sheep's clothing.

ABBY: Oh.

HELENA: I know it sounds weird, and I don't say it too well yet, but when I'm there and Dac is talking-it all makes sense. When you hear him talking, it's all so common-sense it makes you feel stupid that you never thought of it before.

ABBY: Hel, you know I support you in whatever you do ...

HELENA: I know, I *know* -

ABBY: And I know you've been searching ...

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HELENA: Everyone is searching.

ABBY: Yeah, but some more than others.

HELENA: It's the best thing in my life.

ABBY: *[Cautiously.]* It's the only thing in your life ...

HELENA: Dac says that when you commit to God it's all or nothing. Like marriage. You give everything-your heart, your soul, your emotions, your labor and the fruit of your labor-or it's worthless. It's hard, but it's supposed to be hard. If it were easy, then everybody would do it. You have to give up something - sacrifice something-in order to be chosen.

ABBY: Yeah, but who decides when you're chosen?

HELENA: God.

ABBY: But then how do you know ... ? When you're chosen, I mean ...

HELENA: You just do-Dac says it's like re-emerging from the womb. You have to breathe a whole new way. Everything is different, but it's also suddenly the most natural thing in the world.

ABBY: Dac. What is that? Is that a name? It sounds like an e-mail address, or a Pez candy or something.

HELENA: They're initials. Dac says the Judeo-Christian names that we use are tying us to worn-out mythology-superstitions that we no longer need-that are holding us back and imposing these fascist personae on us-and we put that out into the universe without even knowing it. Like Abby ... Abigail. Like *The Scarlet Letter.*

ABBY: What?

HELENA: A marked woman, Abby, an adulteress ... and now it's forced its agenda on your life.

ABBY: You didn't even read *The Scarlet Letter-*

HELENA: But I don't *have* to-that's the point. We all know what happens in the story.

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And I know what happened with you and Jake-

ABBY: The situations are so totally different-

HELENA: I'm not judging you. I'm just saying that when your identity is controlled by your name, then you're *controlled* by destiny.

ABBY: I'm sure there are plenty of women named Mary who get divorced and-I don't know-people named for saints-they screw up too you know ...

HELENA: Oh, sure. Lots of Biblical characters *messed* around. Check it out. I'm not making it up.

ABBY: I'm sure you're not, but with all due respect-which is probably more respect than it deserves-I don't buy it. I'm not being controlled by a very boring work of fiction.

HELENA: It's as real as anything else, you know, by association. It's a cultural myth-it's all fiction really and we collectively-not you Abigail the smart individual-control that. It's like a wave-you know-you can't outrun it.

ABBY: I can't believe we're even having this conversation.

HELENA: I'm just trying to answer your question.

ABBY: Really? Geez, I don't even remember what the question was.

HELENA: The name thing. Dac. He encourages us to create new identities that express our new lives-free from "oppressive cultural fictions" -open to change, rebirth, divine intervention. Dac means everything and no-thing. Whatever you can create: Delicate. Angelic. Creator.

ABBY: Deadly. Amoral. Con-Artist

HELENA: Dreamlike, Alternative, Captain.

ABBY: Deceitful. Arrogant. Cash-man.

HELENA: Divine, Alien, Communicator.

ABBY: Divine Alien Communicator?

HELENA: Just an example.

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ABBY: And who are you?

HELENA: I'm Hep.

ABBY: Hep?

HELENA: I took it from my initials- Helena Elaine Preston.

ABBY: Who the heck is Preston?

HELENA: It's my grandmother's maiden name. I was named for her and Dac believes that I may be partially reincarnated from her because usually we are our own relatives. Which makes sense, if you think about it-the whole thing about the family dynamic and the working out of these repeating patterns. Besides, Dac thought "P" was better than "S:" the serpent's letter. The P offers more ... possibilities. Peace, progress, prophetess ...

ABBY: *[Under her breath.]* Painfully Preyed upon ... Perishing ...

HELENA: *[Somewhat hurt.]* Whatever ... you're just not giving this a chance, and that's fine. One thing Dac warned us about was preaching to our friends ... I just thought you'd be more open-minded.

ABBY: Come on, Hel, we used to laugh at shit like this! Remember those weirdos from science class-cutting themselves and baying at the moon-

HELENA: They were Satin worshippers, Abby ! [*Abby shrugs as if it's all the same.)* Dac is about freedom, about joy-about letting go of all that is weighing us down and sucking the happiness right out of us. It's killing us. It's killing you-look at you.

ABBY: What about me?

HELENA: You know in the Bible people lived to be 120!. I can't believe you're even comparing this to a Satanic cult ... it's called giving *light,* not giving *dark* ... geez Louise.

ABBY: Okay, okay-let's try it again. You can light me up until I catch fire. I won't say anything. Promise. [*Abby offers herself again to get the light.)*

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HELENA: Forget it.

ABBY: Why?

HELENA: Forget about it. You aren't taking this seriously. [*Abby briefly considers arguing, but she's been caught.)*

ABBY: I'm sorry, you're right. *[Silence.]* Sorry. Okay.

HELENA: It's just that I've found something so good and meaningful and right and I want to share it. Is that okay?

ABBY: Of course it's okay.

HELENA: You can't imagine how wonderful it is for me there. I've never felt so wanted and like I belong and full of spirit. Really full. Like they told us it would be but it never was. It's like I'm Mary every day. The woman of God, His beloved. The beloved of God. And I can feel it inside me ... more than ... more than sex is inside. Not like sex, but sensual. A buzzing. A caress. Inside caress, all buzzy warm and pulsing. Like a wave of love and breathlessness. Like a new love all over again every time and every day it gets stronger. *[Pause.]* I know you think I'm out of my mind. You think it's in my mind. That he's in my mind: Dac. But He ... the big He ... is the one. Inside me. Inside. Be still and He is. Inside me ... *[They sit in awkwardly for a bit. Abby cannot find a response.]*

ABBY: It sounds nice. It does. So ... they let you ... drink beer?

HELENA: Yeah, sure. They aren't Nazis, you know. Dac drinks whiskey, says it's more pure, but he doesn't mind beer. He'll have a beer chaser sometimes. *[Another awkward silence.]* Abby ... ?

ABBY: Yeah.

HELENA: Do you ever think of me?

ABBY: Yeah, sure. If I didn't think about you, then I wouldn't have recognized you when you called, right?

HELENA: That's just remembering me, not really thinking about me.

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ABBY: I guess. I don't know. Why?

HELENA: Just curious ...

ABBY: Yeah?

HELENA: It's funny, you know, the past is a dream to me now. Like my whole life up until now happened to another person.

ABBY: I know what you mean. It's like remembering in black and white.

HELENA: Dac says that the more we break free of our past personae, the more we forget the world of our past.

ABBY: You mean, like, you'd forget me?

HELENA: ... And that's kind of okay ... 'cause there's lots of stuff that I want to forget, right? But to let go of everything-even the good-and it was good, don't you think?

ABBY: It was more ... simple.

HELENA: Safe.

ABBY: So that's what this is all about?

HELENA: What?

ABBY: It's like a good-bye. Am I right?

HELENA: Not so much a good-bye as a stroll down memory lane ...

ABBY: Before the memory of me disappears completely. Great. That's just great. You know-ten years-nothing. No phone call. Nothing. Then at my darkest moment here's my bestest, oldest friend and I think-great, a sign. Life goes on. But no, it's all just another big *basta la vista, Abby.*

HELENA: The phone works both ways, you know.

ABBY: *[Lamely joking.]* Maybe my dialing finger was broken.

HELENA: Maybe my entire hand was crushed in a freak circus accident.

ABBY: I was deaf.

HELENA: I was dumb.

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ABBY: Oh yeah? Well, I was in a sucky, controlling marriage.

HELENA: Okay. You win.

ABBY: Yes! [*A pause.]* Stay, Hel. You can stay with me.

HELENA: Abby -

ABBY: Don't decide-just think about it. It's an option.

HELENA: You don't understand, Abbs. With Dac, I'm divine ...

ABBY: Yeah, but are you happy?

HELENA: Don't I seem happy?

ABBY: I don't know, kind of. .. but an unreal happy ...

HELENA: Jealous?

ABBY: Yeah, right.

HELENA: Are you?

ABBY: Jealous?

HELENA: Happy.

ABBY: Hel-

HELENA: Are-you-happy?

ABBY: No. Okay. Life's a roller coaster. You go up, you go down-maybe you learn something and then maybe you're not such a screaming asshole the next time. [*Helena shrugs. It may be so.]* So maybe I have no business grilling you about being happy; heaven knows I haven't got all the answers. But I have been happy, I will be happy. And I'm not willing to give up everything-forget everyone-everything that came before. That doesn't even make sense. I mean, what is left? Right? If you don't have ... remembering. Remembering is as close to happy as I can get some days.

HELENA: But what if it were all like this-like it is right now-? Perfect moments-and the world wouldn't crash in tomorrow morning and screw it all up. What if every asshole thing you'd done-or was done to you-was just gone. Blip. Clean slate.

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What if that's the trade-off. An eternity of perfect moments, instead of suffering over *stuff* that's so far gone you can't even touch the memory of it.

ABBY: But the world's not like that, Hel ...

HELENA: But what if it is? What if it is and we're just not playing it that way? Why shouldn't it be like this?

ABBY: You know, I really am going to miss you, Hel. Just knowing that I could call you-you know-even though I never did.

HELENA: Yeah. I'll miss you. Miss this.

ABBY: No you won't. You'll forget ... remember?

HELENA: True.

ABBY: Not even the pleasure of remembering you forgot. You'll wake up one morning and the memory of me will gone-but I'll miss the good ol' days for both of us, okay?

HELENA: You don't have to, Abbs. It's a choice.

ABBY: I know. *[They sit for a moment and take in the evening.]* Let's try it again: the light thing.

HELENA: I don't know ...

ABBY: Look, I may never touch the divine-but honestly, I could sure use some light in my life, so if you've got some to spare ... and you're willing to give it, with the understanding of course that I don't believe a word of it ... [Helena *smiles. She positions her hand in front of Abby's head and focuses with her eyes closed. Abby looks at Helena intently.]*

HELENA: *[Eyes still closed.]* Are you feeling something this time? [*Abby studies Helena's face, with a mix of love, some sorrow-under it all is perhaps even some jealousy in spite of her disbelief She reaches up as if to touch Helena's hand, but does not. She caresses the air around her: an invisible touch.]*

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ABBY: Yeah … something … *[They sit for some time giving/receiving light …] [Fade to black.]*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jeni Mahoney
Book: The Best American Short Plays 2007-2008
ISBN: 978-1557837509
Publisher: Applause Books
Date (Month/Year): July 2009

AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

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